



Welcome to the OSGeo:UK Newsletter

Hello and welcome to the OSGeo:UK newsletter in which we share updates and information every couple of months about the OSGeo:UK local chapter along with general FOSS for geospatial goodness. Please share the newsletter widely. Interested folks can [sign up](#) too. For now, please enjoy this edition.

News from OSGeo:UK

Find out more about OSGeo:UK and how you can be part of our community on our [website](#).

FOSS4G:UK 2024 South West

And so the event has come and gone! On the 12th November the local organising crew of six (Illya, Sam, Dan, Ant, Pascal and Al) delivered on their hard work over the summer months: [FOSS4G:UK 2024 South West](#) was a great day of presentations and catching up with friends. We sold out our ticket allocation and Bristol was able to welcome over 60 attendees to enjoy hearing from 15 speakers (14 presentations, but one was a tag-team of speakers). It really was a great day of free and open source software, geospatial technologies and open data, and community. All of the presentations were of a high standard and enjoyable and interesting to listen to. To provide you with an idea of the diversity of topics, here is a brief summary of some of those talks (n.b. inclusion or omission from this segment is not an indicator of quality, but more what caught my eye and can fit in the space available here).

Alison Hopkin from CGI was up first and spoke about the trials that she and her team had been involved with in terms of demonstrating how satcomms can improve communications on the railways in areas where terrestrial communications are 'gappy'. There was lots of discussion regarding the technology used, and the success of the initial findings, but I think most people in the audience were just a little bit envious that project staff got to trundle up and down the North York Moors Railway as part of the testing. Not a bad office for a day! Another well received presentation came from Robin Wilson, and outlined some of his web application work with Rebalance Earth. The app itself highlights businesses and assets at risk from flooding, and as Robin himself said... "it's just intersection, but with lots of data and lots of flexibility". The compelling part of the presentation were the findings around the use of on-the-computation of map tiles to be served to the front-end, and how modern cloud-native tools such as titiler can be used to optimise this process.

There was a fascinating talk for all those interested in the presentation of spatial data to non-spatial audiences (and spatial folks too!) given by Alexei Schwab. He had done what free and open source software allows you to do so well: he had scratched his own itch. By which I mean that he wanted specifically structured map layouts in QGIS and they didn't exist, so without any experience of plugin development he rolled up his sleeves and created a plugin that applies modular grids to map layouts. In this talk we learnt what it is like to develop a tool like this from scratch and what the pitfalls might be when trying to learn and develop at the same time, as well as the satisfaction of being able to create the tools you need. Finally here, we highlight another great talk from Matt Travis on Overture and duckDB. Alastair Graham had compared Overture data to some common data sources earlier in the day and Matt built on this to explain what Overture was trying to do, and how duckDB is a powerful tool for interacting and analysing the dataset. It really seems as if there is a lot of activity in geospatial at the moment looking to embrace improved methods of handling the vast amounts of data being collected and mapped.

One moment that perfectly encapsulated the ethos of what FOSS4G meetings deliver (i.e. the ability for any topic or speaker to be welcome as long as it has a relevance to geospatial and openness) was the juxtaposition of Adam Tweedie's talk and that by David Lovelace. We went from discussing the details of CSS and React front-end components to mapping historic trees using tithe maps created in the 1880s. Brilliant!

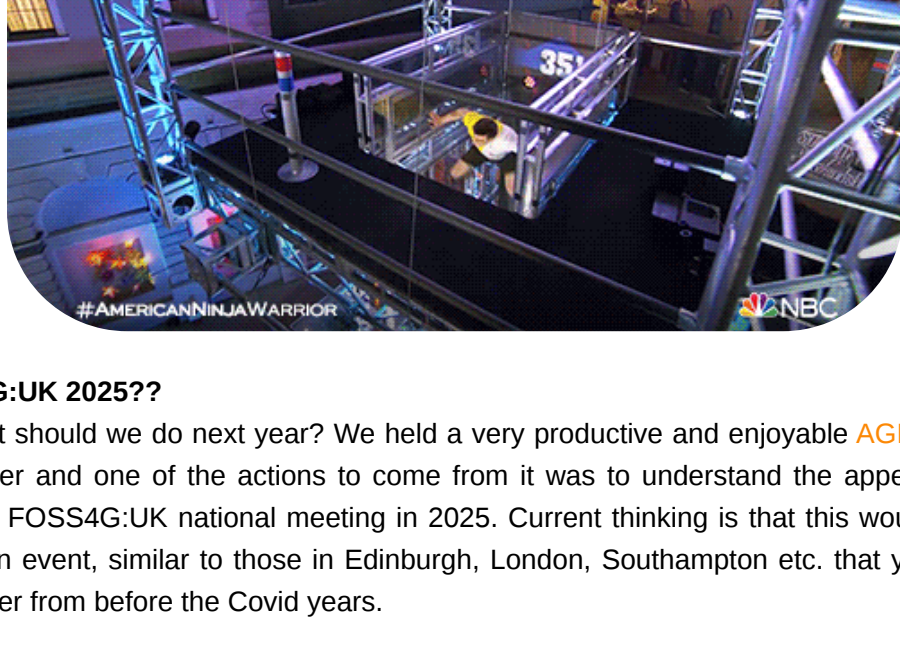
We send our thanks to all of the sponsors: [CGI](#), [Telespazio](#), [Astun Technology](#) and [Locate Press](#). The support of sponsors really helps keep going events such as this one. We also thank the venue, the EngineShed, and all the organisers, presenters and attendees.

The presentation slides for the day are now live (check out: <https://uk.osgeo.org/foss4guk2024/bristol.html#programme>).

We have a winner

Thank you to all of the delegates at the Bristol event who completed the feedback form. Not only is it interesting and lovely to read your comments but it is also helpful for planning future #foss4g events in the UK.

The OSGeo:UK committee are very happy to confirm that Ciaran Sweet of [Development Seed](#) has won an e-book copy of "Using R as a GIS" by Nick Bearman, from Locate Press (<https://locatepress.com/book/rgis>). Congratulations!



FOSS4G:UK 2025??

So, what should we do next year? We held a very productive and enjoyable [AGM](#) in mid-November and one of the actions to come from it was to understand the appetite for a possible FOSS4G:UK national meeting in 2025. Current thinking is that this would be an in-person event, similar to those in Edinburgh, London, Southampton etc. that you might remember from before the Covid years.

The OSGeo:UK committee are keen to support such an event in 2025 and we would like your suggestions for

- 1) a location (and possibly a venue),
- 2) your favoured time of year for such an event,
- 3) whether this should be a one or two day event, and (most importantly)
- 4) are you interested in volunteering to be part of an organising committee?

Remember - your answers to Q1-3 are important but the event can only really happen if your answer to Q4 is 'yes' :-)

Please post your thoughts to [the list](#), or osgeouk@gmail.com

Communication

We are aware that there are many contact points for OSGeo:UK. The key ones are the website - anything that needs to be communicated to the UK community will be posted there. The email mailing list remains in operation for community members and OSGeo:UK to broadcast messages out to those signed up. This newsletter provides updates every two months on topics directly affecting OSGeo:UK and of wider interest.

We now have a number of social media accounts under both osgeouk and foss4guk monikers, and often using #foss4guk #osgeouk or hashtags for a specific event such as #foss4guk2024, so check out [Mastodon](#) and [BlueSky](#) if you are on those platforms. We currently retain our accounts on [X](#) but have noticed the decrease in followers that mirrors the wider move away from the platform. Finally we have a new page on [LinkedIn](#).



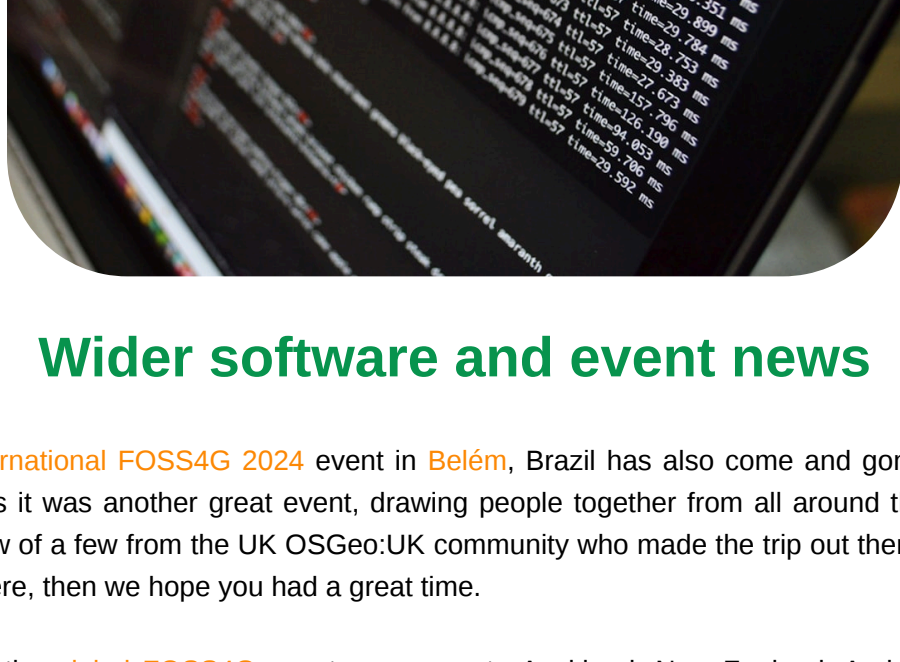
OSGeo-related Projects

GoFundGeo

At the AGM the latest round of GoFundGeo was agreed and awarded. All of the submitted proposals received some form of support. The specific awards are shown below:

- pgRouting Gold Sponsorship Level: \$1200/£963 per year
- QGIS Sustaining Membership small level: €1,000/£840 per year
- qgis2web: Supporting ongoing development of qgis2web, £1000
- GeoServer: £1,000
- Terra Draw, James Milner: £1,000
- GISRUUK & OSGeo:UK GoFundGeo Award: £200

It was suggested for the 2025 awards next November that OSGeo:UK considers wider diversity goals, improved academic links, and an encouragement of UK-centred bids. Everyone on the committee encourages you to submit bids next year for a project or projects that you would like to see funded by us.



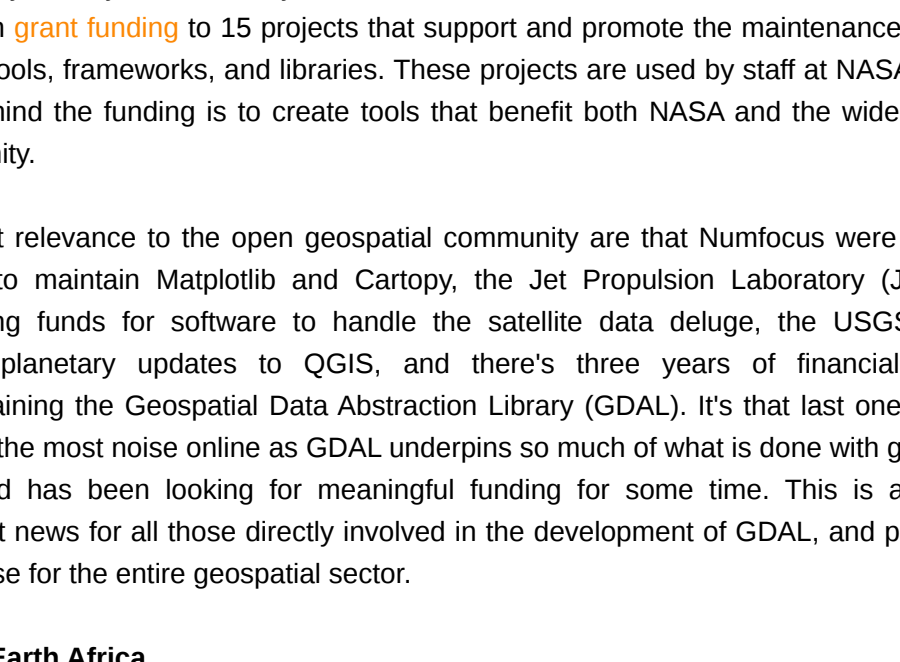
Wider software and event news

The [international FOSS4G 2024](#) event in [Belém](#), Brazil has also come and gone. By all accounts it was another great event, drawing people together from all around the world. We know of a few from the UK OSGeo:UK community who made the trip out there - if you were there, then we hope you had a great time.

In 2025 the [global FOSS4G](#) event moves on to Auckland, New Zealand. And closer to home, [FOSS4G Europe 2025](#) will be held in Mostar, Bosnia-Herzegovina in July.

Other events

Remember, if you are interested in sorting out your calendar for 2025 then checkout this [handy list](#) from [Jakub Nowosad](#) and if you are putting on a geo event with a link to open source software and want it to be mentioned in the newsletter then please get in touch via the details on the OSGeo:UK website. And consider adding it to Jakub's online list.



In wider geospatial FOSS news...

Many of you may have already seen the news that NASA has awarded more than \$15 million in [grant funding](#) to 15 projects that support and promote the maintenance of open-source tools, frameworks, and libraries. These projects are used by staff at NASA, but the idea behind the funding is to create tools that benefit both NASA and the wider science community.

Of direct relevance to the open geospatial community are that Numfocus were awarded money to maintain Matplotlib and Cartopy, the Jet Propulsion Laboratory (JPL) won sustaining funds for software to handle the satellite data deluge, the USGS will be adding planetary updates to QGIS, and there's three years of financial support for sustaining the Geospatial Data Abstraction Library (GDAL). It's that last one that has created the most noise online as GDAL underpins so much of what is done with geospatial data and has been looking for meaningful funding for some time. This is absolutely excellent news for all those directly involved in the development of GDAL, and provides a solid base for the entire geospatial sector.

Digital Earth Africa

A bit of a mix between open and proprietary software in this [next story](#), but it nicely exemplifies the application of geospatial technology to environmental challenges. Specialising in supporting conservation organisations, MAPSS (M.A.P. Scientific Services), a South African organisation, has been using geospatial tools and earth observation data to enhance the management of under-resourced landscapes: specifically [Digital Earth Africa](#), a platform providing open access to mainly open geospatial data. Leveraging Digital Earth Africa's Sentinel-2 data and using ESRI's ArcGIS platform, MAPSS undertakes studies into land cover classification and predictive modelling designed to address habitat changes, monitor wildlife movements, and reduce human-wildlife conflict. "Digital Earth Africa provides a vast repository of analysis-ready satellite data ... accessible via the Africa GeoPortal," says one of the MAPSS owners, Andrew Purdon.

This data-driven approach has had significant ecological and operational impacts, enabling NGOs and government bodies across Africa to monitor vast landscapes and make informed decisions. By offering accessible geospatial data, Digital Earth Africa allows organisations to address conservation challenges effectively, spanning multiple African nations. As a model for private sector innovation, MAPSS demonstrates the potential of combining advanced geospatial technologies with actionable data to tackle environmental challenges. This shows that Digital Earth Africa is shaping the future of conservation and sustainable development on the continent.

We hope that you found this edition of the newsletter interesting and informative. If you have any feedback or comments then let us know!



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